

Comparative Essay on Isolation and Monstrosity in Asterion and Frankenstein

In this essay, my aim is to explore the themes of isolation and monstrosity in Borges's "The House of Asterion" and Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*. Both stories delve into the psychological and social dimensions of being an outcast, challenging traditional notions of monstrosity and heroism.

Both Borges's "The House of Asterion" and Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* explore profound themes of isolation and monstrosity. The protagonists, Asterion and Frankenstein's Creature are not only isolated physically but also misunderstood by society, which labels them as monsters. Through these characters, Borges and Shelley challenge conventional notions of monstrosity and heroism, highlighting the psychological and social dimensions of being an outcast.

The myth of the Minotaur begins with Minos, who asked Poseidon for a sign to prove to the Cretans that he was favored by the gods. Poseidon sent a beautiful bull from the sea, which Minos was supposed to sacrifice. However, Minos found the bull too beautiful to kill and kept it. Angered, Poseidon made Queen Pasiphae fall in love with the bull. She enlisted Daedalus to create a wooden heifer for her to hide inside, allowing her to mate with the bull. The result of this union was the Minotaur, Asterion, who had the head of a bull and the body of a man.

Furious and ashamed, Minos had Daedalus construct a massive palace-prison, the labyrinth, to contain the Minotaur. Every year (or every nine years), seven youths and seven maidens from Athens were sent into the labyrinth as a tribute to the Minotaur. Eventually, Theseus volunteered to join the group of youths and, with the help of a thread given to him by Ariadne, navigated the labyrinth, killed the Minotaur, and emerged triumphant.

In Borges's "The House of Asterion," the story is told from the perspective of Asterion, the Minotaur. Asterion describes his life in a labyrinthine house, where he lives in complete isolation, disconnected from the outside world.

Born from the union of a human mother and a bull father, he embodies the traits of two different worlds yet he is rejected by both. His liminal existence, neither fully human nor fully bull, like the labyrinth he inhabits, is a manifestation of this in-between state.

The Minotaur's labyrinth has no locks, allowing him the illusion of freedom. Yet, stepping outside its confines only exposes him to a world that fears and misunderstands him. The Cretans fear the Minotaur and he, in turn, mirrors their apprehension and he fears them.

equally. Though he has the freedom to leave, the minotaur remains within the walls of his house for it is the only place where he is truly recognized and accepted, if only by himself.

“The house is the same size as the world; or rather it is the world”

His house reflects the paradox of his existence –a world unto himself yet forever barred from true acceptance elsewhere. In this labyrinth, he finds solace in his solitude, for it is the only place where he truly belongs.

Asterion considers his labyrinth as a religious place. He narrates, “every nine years, nine men come into the house so that I can free them of all evil”

The reason why people come to his temple is so that he can perform the sacred ceremony of saving them, however In the story there is no clear implication of Asterion actually killing the humans, this is a game for him. He runs joyfully to find them, but they fall one after another without him having to bloody his hands. The Minotaur kills the tributes who come to him, not because he is a fierce animal but because he believes that it's what they want from him: because that is what he desires from *his* redeemer, who arrives in the form of Theseus. He considers death a sweet escape and murder a service. He is well-meaning, naive and innocent like a little child. His own desire for death, eagerly waiting for his redeemer is a clear example of his views on death. He may well be biologically mature, but psychologically he is ever a child, conflating joy with death and play with murder.

He also plays his little games when he's left alone. He makes up imaginary friends like the other Asterion and he plays pretend; He runs through the stone galleries and falls dizzy to the ground just like the way tribute sent to his house runs away from him. He pretends he's being followed, he pretends like the only humans he has interaction with: his victims.

Borges encourages us to respond to the Minotaur differently: he is no longer just an antagonist in someone else's story but the narrator of his own life. Ostracised for being different ‘The House of Asterion’ is symbolic of society's tendency to ‘other’ those who are different

Similarly, in *Frankenstein*, Shelley presents the Creature as a complex character rather than a mere monster. Created by Victor Frankenstein, the Creature grapples with his rejection by his creator and society, ultimately seeking revenge through murder and terror. Both characters embody the theme of liminality, existing on the threshold between categories. Asterion, with a human mother and a bull father, is neither fully human nor fully beast. He lives in a labyrinth that symbolizes his liminal existence—neither entirely inside nor outside, but in a state of in-betweenness. Borges paints Asterion as a misunderstood being whose violent actions stem from his distorted perception of his role and identity.

Frankenstein's Creature is also a liminal being, assembled from various human parts yet rejected by humanity. He does not fit any traditional human category, feeling neither like Adam nor a companion: "I am alone and miserable: man will not associate with me." His monstrous label is a result of societal rejection rather than his inherent nature. Shelley critiques how society's inability to accept differences creates the very monsters it fears. He becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy: he becomes what others, and he himself, believe him to be. Just like Asterion, the Creature also mirrors the way he's treated by others. When he feels accepted by the De Lacey family, he expresses his feelings as: "The gentle manners and beauty of the cottagers greatly endeared them to me; when they were unhappy, I felt depressed; when they rejoiced, I sympathized in their joys."

Narrative perspective further enhances our understanding of isolation and monstrosity in both texts. Borges tells Asterion's story from his perspective, humanizing him and challenging traditional perceptions of monsters. Through Asterion's narration, readers empathize with his experiences of rejection and loneliness, questioning the nature of heroism and villainy. Similarly, Shelley allows the Creature to narrate his own tale, inviting readers to witness his struggles for acceptance and redemption amidst societal prejudice. Borges and Shelley prompt readers to reconsider their perceptions of monstrosity and heroism, highlighting society's tendency to "other" those who are different.

Both Asterion and the Creature are trapped in a cycle of fear and contention with humanity. The Cretans fear Asterion, and he fears them in return, leading to his eventual murder by Theseus, which Borges portrays not as a triumph but a tragedy. This demythologizing of the hero-myth suggests that heroism often involves destroying what is not understood. In *Frankenstein*, the Creature's fear and hatred toward humanity grow as he faces continual rejection. His initial benevolence turns into vengeful violence, mirroring the way he is treated. Shelley's narrative shows that monstrosity is not an inherent trait but a result of societal exclusion and prejudice.

Through their respective narratives, Borges and Shelley challenge readers to reconsider the nature of monstrosity, suggesting that it is not an innate characteristic but a reflection of how society treats those who are different. Both Asterion and the Creature are tragic figures, defined not by their inherent qualities but by their isolation and the misunderstanding they face from the world around them